

Practice Paper 2: Answers and Marking Guide

Fear and courage; love, loyalty and pride · Three hours · 100 marks

PAPER I · 40 MARKS

Answer **all** the questions in Section A. Select **either** I, II **or** III from Section B and answer all the questions given below it.

Paper I · Section A: Poetry, Prose and Drama 30 marks

Read the following extracts and answer all the questions given below them.

I POETRY

I (i) · PRACTICE QUESTION

"He glanced with rapid eyes,
That hurried all abroad -
They looked like frightened Beads, I thought,
He stirred his Velvet Head."

- (a) Name the poem from which these lines are taken. Name the poet. 1 mark
- (b) Who is referred to as 'He'? 1 mark
- (c) Name the poetic technique used in the third line. 1 mark
- (d) What do these lines show about the bird's state of mind and the speaker's attitude? 2 marks

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- (a) "A Bird Came Down the Walk" by Emily Dickinson.
 - (b) The bird that has come down the garden walk.
 - (c) Simile: the bird's eyes are compared to frightened beads.
 - (d) The bird is nervous, alert and cautious, looking all around for danger. The speaker watches closely and with sympathy and admiration; "Velvet Head" shows her delight in its soft beauty.

I (ii) · PRACTICE QUESTION

"Not that this troubled him one bit;
in fact, he was quite glad of it,
knowing it's every sane man's mission
to contradict all superstition."

- (a) Name the poem from which these lines are taken. Name the poet. 1 mark
- (b) Who is referred to as 'him'? 1 mark
- (c) What is 'this' that did not trouble him? 1 mark
- (d) How do these lines prepare the reader for the poem's humorous ending? 2 marks
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- (a) "Two's Company" by Raymond Wilson.
- (b) The man who laughed at the idea that the house was haunted and stayed there alone for the night.
- (c) Being left alone in the "haunted" house as night fell, with the moon and screech owls.
- (d) They show his over-confidence: he believes he is rational and above superstition. This sets up dramatic irony, because he soon becomes frightened, locks the doors, hides in the cupboard and meets the ghost.

II PROSE

II (i) • PRACTICE QUESTION

"'Death is a great price to pay for a red rose,' cried the Nightingale, 'and Life is very dear to all.'"

- (a) Name the text from which these lines are taken. Name the author. 1 mark
- (b) To whom is the Nightingale speaking? 1 mark
- (c) What price must she pay? 1 mark
- (d) What does her final decision show about her? 2 marks
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- (a) "The Nightingale and the Rose" by Oscar Wilde.
- (b) The Rose-tree growing beneath the Student's window.
- (c) She must sing all night with her breast against a thorn until it pierces her heart, so that her blood colours the rose. She will die.
- (d) She decides that "Love is better than Life", so she shows courage, selflessness and a firm belief in true love. She is willing to sacrifice her life for someone else's happiness.

II (ii) • PRACTICE QUESTION

"The jeep rocked. It was floating, the wheels no longer gripping the ground. We kept steadying ourselves on the seats. No one spoke. No one uttered a sound."

- (a) Name the text from which these lines are taken. Name the author. 1 mark
- (b) Who are 'we'? 1 mark
- (c) Why was the jeep floating? 1 mark
- (d) Comment on the effect of the short sentences. 2 marks
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- (a) An extract from "Wave" by Sonali Deraniyagala.
- (b) The narrator and her family, escaping from the tsunami in a jeep.
- (c) The tsunami had flooded the land, and the water lifted the jeep off the ground.
- (d) They create tension and a breathless, frightening pace. The silence ("No one spoke") shows shock, fear and helplessness: everyone is too terrified to speak.

III DRAMA

III (i) • PRACTICE QUESTION

"Well, now, it's very nice to have got two pieces of the cloth—God bless us!"

- (a) Name the play from which these lines are taken. Name the playwright. 1 mark
- (b) Who speaks these words? 1 mark
- (c) When are they spoken? 1 mark
- (d) What impression of the speaker do you get from these words? 2 marks
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- (a) "Twilight of a Crane" by Junji Kinoshita.
- (b) Sodo.
- (c) At the end of the play, when Tsu leaves Yohyo in the form of a crane after leaving two pieces of senba-ori cloth.
- (d) He is selfish, callous and money-minded: while Yohyo has lost his wife, Sodo cares only about the valuable cloth and the profit it will bring.

III (ii) • PRACTICE QUESTION

"You will see, Nicolas, how I can love and forgive.... My love will die out with me, only when this poor heart will cease to beat."

- (a) Name the play from which these lines are taken. Name the playwright. 1 mark
- (b) Who is the speaker? 1 mark

(c) Who is 'Nicolas', and what is the speaker doing as she says this?

1 mark

(d) Are these words sincere? Give a reason from the play.

2 marks

(a) "The Bear" by Anton Chekhov.

(b) Popova.

(c) Nicolas is her dead husband; she is looking at his photograph.

(d) They are exaggerated and partly pretence. She knows he was unfaithful and cruel, and she soon forgets her vow when she falls in love with Smirnov. The lines prepare for the comic reversal.

Paper I · Section B: Novels 10 marks

Select **EITHER** I, II **OR** III and answer all the questions given below it.

I · THE PRINCE AND THE PAUPER

Read the following extract from *The Prince and the Pauper* by Mark Twain and answer all the questions given below it.

"Hendon despatched his ablutions with alacrity, then drew back the other chair and was about to place himself at table, when the boy said, indignantly—

"Forbear! Wouldst sit in the presence of the King?"

This blow staggered Hendon to his foundations. He muttered to himself, "Lo, the poor thing's madness is up with the time! It hath changed with the great change that is come to the realm, and now in fancy is he king! Good lack, I must humour the conceit, too—there is no other way—faith, he would order me to the Tower, else!"

And pleased with this jest, he removed the chair from the table, took his stand behind the King, and proceeded to wait upon him in the courtliest way he was capable of."

(i) When and where does this incident take place?

2 marks

(ii) Why does Hendon decide to 'humour the conceit'?

2 marks

(iii) Explain the meaning of the following phrase as it occurs in the passage: (a) despatched his ablutions with alacrity

1 mark

(b) staggered Hendon to his foundations

1 mark

(iv) What does this incident reveal about the characters of Edward and Hendon?

4 marks

(i) When and where does this incident take place?

Soon after Miles Hendon has rescued Edward from the mob, in Hendon's lodging at an inn on London Bridge, when they sit down to eat.

(ii) Why does Hendon decide to 'humour the conceit'?

He believes the boy is mad and that the news of the old King's death has made him imagine he is now king. He pities him and thinks it is kinder, and safer, to play along.

(iii) Explain the meaning of the following phrase as it occurs in the passage: (a) despatched his ablutions with alacrity

Washed himself quickly and eagerly.

(b) staggered Hendon to his foundations

Shocked and astonished him completely.

(iv) What does this incident reveal about the characters of Edward and Hendon?

Edward keeps his royal pride and dignity even in rags; he expects to be treated as king. Hendon is kind, patient, good-humoured and generous: he protects a poor boy he thinks is mad and serves him with courtesy. The scene is humorous, and it begins the loyal friendship that is rewarded at the end, when Hendon is given the right to sit in the King's presence.

II • BRINGING TONY HOME

During a lesson at school, the class has burst into laughter and uproar. The teacher, Mr. Jayakody, is coming towards the narrator, and the boy imagines Tony fighting a garden lizard. He says:

"having broken through classroom order there is no wish to get back to it"

(i) When and where does this scene take place? **2 marks**

(ii) Why does the narrator think of Tony at this moment? **2 marks**

(iii) Explain the meaning of the following phrase as it occurs in the passage: (a) broken through classroom order **1 mark**

(b) no wish to get back to it **1 mark**

(iv) What does this incident show about the narrator's character and his relationship with Tony? **4 marks**

(i) When and where does this scene take place?

In the narrator's childhood, in his classroom at school, during a lesson taught by Mr. Jayakody.

(ii) Why does the narrator think of Tony at this moment?

He is frightened of the angry teacher and needs courage. Tony is his protector and friend, so he imagines Tony standing up to the lizard.

(iii) Explain the meaning of the following phrase as it occurs in the passage: (a) broken through classroom order

Destroyed the discipline of the class.

(b) no wish to get back to it

Nobody wants to return to being quiet and disciplined.

(iv) What does this incident show about the narrator's character and his relationship with Tony?

The narrator is lively and mischievous, but also sensitive and imaginative. Under pressure he turns to an imagined scene with Tony, showing how deeply he depends on the dog for courage and comfort. The comparison between the lizard and himself shows he feels like a helpless victim. Theme: the strong bond between boy and dog; childhood fears.

III · THE VENDOR OF SWEETS

Jagan is shown a quiet garden across the river by the bearded man who carves images. They talk about leaving worldly life. Jagan says:

"at some stage in one's life one must uproot oneself from the accustomed surroundings and disappear so that others may continue in peace."

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|---|---------|
| (i) When and where does this conversation take place? | 2 marks |
| (ii) Why does Jagan agree so readily? | 2 marks |
| (iii) Explain the meaning of the following phrase as it occurs in the passage: (a) uproot oneself | 1 mark |
| (b) accustomed surroundings | 1 mark |
| (iv) What stage of life does Jagan think of here? Does his retreat seem sincere? Explain. | 4 marks |
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(i) When and where does this conversation take place?

Near the end of the novel, when Jagan's home life has become unbearable because of Mali; in the garden across the river where the bearded man wants to install an image of the Goddess.

(ii) Why does Jagan agree so readily?

His wife is dead, and Mali's behaviour, his business demands and the truth about Grace have made his home miserable, so he longs to escape.

(iii) Explain the meaning of the following phrase as it occurs in the passage: (a) uproot oneself

Leave the place where one has always lived.

(b) accustomed surroundings

The familiar places and way of life one is used to.

(iv) What stage of life does Jagan think of here? Does his retreat seem sincere? Explain.

He thinks of the traditional Hindu stage of vanaprastha, when a person withdraws from worldly life. His wish is partly sincere, because he is tired and hurt. But it is also an escape from his problems with Mali, and he still keeps his money: he takes his cheque book with him. Themes: father-son conflict; tradition and modernity; the search for peace.

Paper II · Essays 60 marks

PAPER II · 60 MARKS

Answer **four** questions, selecting **one** each from the four sections: Poetry, Drama, Prose and Fiction.

HOW PAPER II ESSAYS ARE MARKED (15 MARKS EACH)

Content 7 · Organisation 4 · Language 4. Examiners reward relevant points from the text, apt quotations, a clear argument that answers the question, and your own sensible response. The points below are a guide, not a fixed list.

POETRY (Answer one question only)

1. "'To the Evening Star' shows both the peace of evening and the dangers of the night."

Discuss.

15 marks

- Introduction: Blake addresses the evening star (Venus) as a "fair-hair'd angel"; apostrophe and personification.
- Peace and love: "light / Thy bright torch of love"; "Smile on our loves".
- Gentle care for nature: "scatter thy silver dew / On every flower that shuts its sweet eyes / In timely sleep".
- Silence and calm: "speak silence with thy glimmering eyes, / And wash the dusk with silver".
- The turn: "Soon, full soon, / Dost thou withdraw; then the wolf rages wide, / And then the lion glares through the dun forest".
- Plea for protection: "protect them with thin influence!"
- Techniques: imagery of light and colour, synaesthesia ("speak silence"), contrast, blank verse.
- Conclusion: the poem balances calm beauty with fear of darkness; good and evil coexist in nature.

2. How does Wislawa Szymborska create suspense in 'The Terrorist, He's Watching'?

15 marks

- Introduction: the poem is told from the point of view of a terrorist who has left a bomb in a bar and watches from a distance.
- Countdown: the exact time (thirteen twenty) and repeated references to the minutes and seconds left create tension.

- Ordinary people: the poet lists people going in and out of the bar, each unaware of the danger; the reader wonders who will be saved.
- Chance: small decisions (going back for something, leaving early) decide life or death.
- The terrorist's cold detachment: he watches from a safe place, like a spectator.
- Dramatic irony: the reader knows about the bomb while the people do not.
- Short lines, plain language and present tense make the scene immediate.
- Conclusion: suspense shows the cruelty and randomness of terrorism.

3. "In 'Richard Cory' the poet shows that wealth and admiration do not guarantee happiness."

Discuss.

15 marks

- Introduction: a narrative poem told by "We people on the pavement", the poor townspeople.
- Richard Cory as a gentleman: "a gentleman from sole to crown, / Clean favored, and imperially slim"; "quietly arrayed".
- He seems perfect: "richer than a king", "admirably schooled in every grace".
- The townspeople envy him: "we thought that he was everything / To make us wish that we were in his place".
- Their poverty: "went without the meat, and cursed the bread".
- Shocking end: "one calm summer night, / Went home and put a bullet through his head."
- Techniques: royal imagery, regular rhyme and rhythm that hide the tragedy, contrast, irony.
- Conclusion: appearances deceive; inner loneliness can lie behind outer success.

4. "In 'Fear', a mother's love is both beautiful and possessive." **Discuss.**

15 marks

- Introduction: Gabriela Mistral's poem, translated by Doris Dana; a mother speaks about her little girl.
- Repetition: "I don't want them to turn / my little girl into a swallow" and "make / my little girl a princess" and "queen".
- The swallow: freedom would take her "far away into the sky" where "I could not comb her hair".
- The princess: "In tiny golden slippers / how could she play on the meadow?"; she would no longer "sleep at my side".
- The queen: "They would put her on a throne / where I could not go to see her."
- Beautiful love: tenderness, closeness, simple joys.

- Possessive love: the mother fears change, growing up and separation.
- Conclusion: a balanced view; the poem expresses a universal parental anxiety.

5. "'The Camel's Hump' teaches a serious lesson through humour." Discuss.

15 marks

- Introduction: a poem by Rudyard Kipling from the Just So Stories.
- The hump as a metaphor for a bad mood caused by idleness: "the hump we get / From having too little to do".
- Humorous descriptions: "frouzly head", "snarly-yarly voice"; "We shiver and scowl and we grunt and we growl".
- Everyone gets it: "Kiddies and grown-ups too-oo-oo".
- The cure: "not to sit still, / Or frowst with a book by the fire; / But to take a large hoe and a shovel also, / And dig till you gently perspire".
- Techniques: made-up words ("Cameelious"), internal rhyme, repetition, a lively refrain.
- Conclusion: humour makes the lesson about work and activity memorable for children and adults.

DRAMA (Answer one question only)

6. Compare and contrast Sodo and Unzu in 'Twilight of a Crane'.

15 marks

- Introduction: two villagers who discover the value of the cloth Tsu weaves.
- Similarities: both want money and use Yohyo; both bring outside, worldly influence into his simple life.
- Sodo: the more greedy and cunning of the two; he plans to make Yohyo demand more cloth; he spies on Tsu while she weaves.
- Unzu: less determined; at times he hesitates or feels uneasy about Sodo's plans.
- Their effect: they turn Yohyo's love into a desire for money.
- At the end: Sodo still thinks of the cloth when Tsu leaves.
- Conclusion: they represent materialism and the destruction of innocence.

7. What is the role of Luka in 'The Bear'?

15 marks

- Introduction: Luka is Popova's old footman.

- He opens the play and gives the background: Popova has stayed indoors mourning for a year; he urges her to enjoy life.
- He represents common sense: "you can't go on weeping and wearing mourning for ever."
- Comic relief: he is bullied by Smirnov and cries "Little fathers!... What people!"
- He increases the farce: he fetches help and the servants arrive with weapons at the end.
- Contrast: his simple, practical view against the exaggerated emotions of the two main characters.
- Conclusion: a minor character with an important dramatic and comic function.

PROSE (Answer one question only)

8. How is the narrator's love for her family revealed in the extract from 'Wave'?

15 marks

- Introduction: a true account of the 2004 tsunami.
- Opening scenes: affectionate description of her sons and family life.
- Her first thought is for her children: she grabs her sons and runs.
- Her husband: she notices his face and sees fear she had never seen before.
- Her actions are instinctive, driven by love and the need to protect.
- The restraint of the writing makes her love and loss more moving.
- Conclusion: love for family is at the heart of the memoir.

9. "Nicholas is the hero of 'The Lumber Room'." Do you agree?

15 marks

- Introduction: Nicholas is a young boy in disgrace.
- Clever and logical: he proves the adults wrong about the frog and insists: "there was a frog in my bread-and-milk".
- A skilled planner: he practises with keys, pretends to try for the gooseberry garden, and slips into the lumber-room.
- Imaginative: the tapestry becomes "a living, breathing story"; he imagines the wolves and the huntsman.
- Brave and witty: he refuses to help the aunt in the tank, calling her "the Evil One".
- Possible objections: he is disobedient and a little cruel.
- Conclusion: personal view supported by evidence; Saki clearly sides with the child.

10. "In 'The Lahore Attack', humour and friendship help the team to recover." Discuss.

15 marks

- Introduction: the shock of the attack.
- After surviving, the players gather: "We all sit in the dressing room and talk."
- Laughter returns: "Within minutes there is laughter and the jokes have started to flow."
- Shared experience creates unity: "We had survived."
- Team spirit shows strength: "we were not cowed".
- Friendship and national pride: "We are Sri Lankan."
- Conclusion: humour and friendship show resilience and the healing power of a team.

11. What is the role of the nature characters (the Lizard, the Butterfly, the Daisy, the Rose-trees and the Oak-tree) in 'The Nightingale and the Rose'?

15 marks

- Introduction: Wilde gives voices to plants and animals, as in a fairy tale.
- The Lizard, the Butterfly and the Daisy mock the Student: "how very ridiculous!"; the Lizard is "something of a cynic".
- The three Rose-trees: white, yellow and red roses build suspense; the red Rose-tree reveals the terrible price.
- The Oak-tree loves the Nightingale: "Sing me one last song"; he feels sad because he understands.
- They contrast with the humans: nature understands love better than the Student.
- Conclusion: these characters add humour, suspense and pathos, and support the theme.

FICTION (Answer one question only)

12. Discuss the importance of Miles Hendon in 'The Prince and the Pauper'.

15 marks

- Introduction: a soldier returning home who rescues Edward from the mob.
- Protector: he believes Edward is mad but cares for him.
- Humour: he humours the boy's "madness", serving him at table.
- His own story: his brother Hugh has taken his inheritance and Lady Edith; injustice in the upper classes.
- Sacrifice: he takes Edward's lashes in the stocks.
- Reward: Edward makes him an Earl and gives him the right to sit in the King's presence.
- Conclusion: he represents loyalty, honour and true nobility.

13. "Tony is not just a pet but a true member of the family." Discuss with reference to 'Bringing Tony Home'.

15 marks

- Introduction: the narrator's dog Tony.
- Seven years of friendship at Depanama.
- The painful parting when the family moves and Tony cannot come.
- The boy's secret vow and the joyful reunion; the "sharp clipped aristocratic bark".
- The long walk back to Wijerama to keep Tony safe.
- Tony seems to understand people and finds his own way of living among them.
- His leaving while the boy is ill causes deep grief.
- Conclusion: Tony is treated as a friend and family member; the human-animal bond is the heart of the novel.

14. "Mali is a product of the way he was brought up." Discuss with reference to 'The Vendor of Sweets'.

15 marks

- Introduction: Mali, Jagan's only son.
- Spoilt by a loving father after his mother's death; Jagan never refuses him.
- He leaves college and goes to America with money taken from his father.
- He returns with Grace and the story-writing machine scheme, demanding money.
- His rude, clipped speech and disrespect for tradition.
- His arrest at the end.
- Other influences: Western life, modern ambitions.
- Conclusion: a balanced answer; Jagan's upbringing and the clash of cultures both shape him.

These are original LitHelp practice questions written to the format of the G.C.E. (O/L) 2023(2024) and 2024(2025) papers and the Ministry of Education's 2025(2026) model papers. They are not official past-paper questions. For copyrighted set texts, only short lines are quoted and the situation is described in our own words.